

# Summer Chase

Conspiracy and identity crisis make this novel a page-turner



**IT ISN'T EASY BEING TAZ**  
by DAWOOD ALI MCCALLUM  
Penguin  
Price: Rs 295  
Pages: 309

■ By Bunny Suraiya

**A**t the crux of this tale is the problem of identity. Identity lost, mistaken, concealed and mixed. Tasneem Dharwalla alias Taz Dhar, first-generation British whose family fled Amin's Uganda, and a functional alcoholic, has come to Mumbai to work as a news anchor for a television channel. On the day she gets fired for substance abuse, she receives a letter from someone who has found her picture, cut from a television guide. The writer is scheduled to be executed in an unknown African prison and has chosen to write his last letter to a face from the media, Taz. His name is Armitage Shanks—a name found on toilets throughout Britain and its erstwhile empire. But newspaper and Internet sources report no such execution having taken place and no one by such a name seems ever to have existed.

Taz persuades her boss (by dint of some rather amateurish blackmail) to sponsor her pursuit of this mysterious story. This results in a breathless chase that takes her from England to Ethiopia to Ghana, to Gambia, back to England and finally to India, pursued by threats, sinister phone calls and dire warnings to abandon her quest. Fuzzy-headed and drunk much of the time, Taz is not able to give up what has rapidly become an obsession, and the plot thickens into an unlikely international conspiracy that she, more by luck than skill, manages to unravel.

A decided page-turner, this book makes for enjoyable summer holiday reading, but could have done with tighter editing; there are tiresome longueurs when Taz is in her drunken fugues, but the characters are well-rounded and, much praise to the author, none of the Indians speaks like Peter Sellers.

## TOP 10

BESTSELLERS

A monthly national list of bestselling books compiled for INDIA TODAY by ORG-MARG based on data from 15 retail outlets in six cities.

### FICTION

| NO.     | TITLE                                     | AUTHOR        | PUBLISHER     |
|---------|-------------------------------------------|---------------|---------------|
| 1. (20) | The Witch of Portobello                   | Paulo Coelho  | HarperCollins |
| 2. (-)  | Five Point Someone: What Not to Do At IIT | Chetan Bhagat | Rupa          |
| 3. (4)  | The Namesake                              | Jhumpa Lahiri | HarperCollins |
| 4. (1)  | The Inheritance of Loss                   | Kiran Desai   | Penguin       |
| 5. (-)  | One Night @ the Call Centre               | Chetan Bhagat | Rupa          |

### NON-FICTION

| NO.     | TITLE                         | AUTHOR                          | PUBLISHER        |
|---------|-------------------------------|---------------------------------|------------------|
| 1. (1)  | It Happened in India          | Kishore Biyani, Dipayan Baishya | Rupa             |
| 2. (5)  | The Secret                    | Rhonda Byrne                    | Atria            |
| 3. (15) | Screw It, Let's Do it         | Richard Branson                 | Virgin           |
| 4. (4)  | Dhirubhaism                   | A.G. Krishnamurthy              | Tata McGraw-Hill |
| 5. (3)  | The Monk Who Sold His Ferrari | Robin S. Sharma                 | Jaico            |

### OTHER INDIAN BOOKS IN THE TOP 20

#### FICTION

| NO.    | TITLE         | AUTHOR                | PUBLISHER     |
|--------|---------------|-----------------------|---------------|
| 7. (9) | Above Average | Amitabha Bagchi       | HarperCollins |
| 8. (7) | Shantaram     | Gregory David Roberts | Penguin       |

#### NON-FICTION

| NO.      | TITLE                                                     | AUTHOR           | PUBLISHER        |
|----------|-----------------------------------------------------------|------------------|------------------|
| 6. (19)  | India After Gandhi                                        | Ramachandra Guha | Picador          |
| 7. (6)   | Dabbawalas                                                | Shrinivas Pandit | Tata McGraw-Hill |
| 8. (8)   | The Greatness Guide                                       | Robin S. Sharma  | Jaico            |
| 9. (11)  | Maximum City: Bombay Lost and Found                       | Suketu Mehta     | Penguin          |
| 11. (18) | India's Politics: A View From the Back Bench              | Bimal Jalan      | Penguin          |
| 12. (9)  | Mohandas: A True Story of a Man, his People and an Empire | Rajmohan Gandhi  | Penguin          |

Last month's rating in brackets

Participating bookshops: Delhi: Om Book Shop, Faqir Chand, Toksons, Full Circle; Mumbai: Crossword, Shah Book Stall, Danai Book Shop; Bangalore: Fountainhead, Gangarams; Hyderabad: Walden Book Link, The Book Point; Kolkata: Oxford Books, Modern Book Depot, Family Book Shop; Chennai: Fountainhead